

more about the CSM's responsibility with respect to Customer Success Plans.

Resources

This Google Drive Folder contains the Mutual Customer Success Plan starting template, an instructional walkthrough, and example Customer Success Plans for Ultimate and Dedicated as a reference.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/strategic-solution-selling/index.md

This is a practice guide for a Solutions Architect (SA) to engage enterprises for driving a strategic solution during discovery and scoping stage, which can lead into the technical evaluation.

A strategic solution is aimed to provide a customer the DevOps capabilities for delivering software better and faster with an organizational wide impact and aligned with the enterprise transformational initiatives. The SA will assess and provide the solutioning as the right fit for the enterprise from the business and technical perspectives. The solution should align with the business outcomes that can be realized based on the DevOps roadmap vision. Further the solution can accelerate the customer's DevOps transformation at scale.

Analyze and Gather Information

When an opportunity is qualified during the discovery by a Strategic Account Executive (SAE), the SAE will work with the SA and decide the plan for next steps. The SA may conduct a technical discovery on the first call with the customer. Then the SA can start the analysis for scoping.

The following diagram shows the mindset for the SA to consider when expanding the technical feature considerations to the strategic solutioning, specifically the information that needs to be discovered and gathered. It involves various activities based on the SAE and SA being engaged with a customer during the discovery and scoping.

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Note: To increase the size of the diagram, press "full screen" icon in the top right corner and increase the size via "zoom options" in the bottom right corner.

Strategic Outcomes play a key role in the overall Strategic Solution Selling process. The below points provide a short introduction.

Roadmap - shows key milestones focusing on GitLab solutions and capabilities. The roadmap

should be aligned with the customer's business strategy and key initiatives and be supported by the IT / Business alignment deliverables. Additionally, the roadmap will be very beneficial for the Technical Account manager (CSM) to understand the required next steps and the strategic decisions clearly.

Stakeholders - identified essential technical and business stakeholders who will drive the initiatives, pre-sales and post-sales engagement.

From the Solution Architecture point of view, it is important to identify the technical decision makers, internal advocates or champions, influencers, as well as saboteurs (the person who is benefiting from the current solution).

Current State - a better understanding of why the change is needed regarding the Enterprise / Account environment. The business need(s) and changes required should be an input for defining the "Future State".

Future State - the future state organisation focuses on DevOps and DevSecOps, ensuring the key stakeholders have a shared vision of the business outcome. It is very beneficial to define the conditions to meet the business requirements.

Activities for SA to Consider

Research and analysis of the opportunity are critical to identify the strategic direction of the "scoping" and "technical evaluation" stages which may require SA lead technical discovery. Technical discovery activity should provide advantageous knowledge to help navigate the conversations with the customer. This can be even more crucial for a new logo, where the relationship with the prospect has not been well established yet.

Since these activities require extensive work, there needs to be pre qualification of the opportunity for the consideration based on the personas engaged and the size of the opportunity.

Discovery should be based on the SAE and SA collaboration but is owned by the SAE. Business-related information will be more easily identified by the SAE, where as the SA can lead to identify technical challenges, the technology landscape and aligned key GitLab capabilities based on the customer environment. The initial discovery information can better equip the SA with the knowledge for the further discussions with the customer.

The initial information is based on various sources of information, which can be found, for example via public channels, such as LinkedIn, Company blogs, or public reports. Although the initial analysis step might not always expose the pain points for the customer it is vital to them which might be used for future discussions with the customer. It will help to align and to address the future value proposition.

Technical Discovery Approach

SA teams have mapped out technical discovery approach with pre call preparation, conducting the call and followed by the strategic planning. Refer to these documents for details:

- SA Technical Discovery Process & Guide: The goal of this document is to provide a workflow on how to conduct better technical discovery calls with customers to ensure we are aligned for an

efficient technical evaluation. (for internal access only)

- SA Modern Apps Discovery Process & Guide: The goal of this document is to provide guidance for technical discovery & process for assisting our customers with their modern applications journey. (for internal access only)

Tools for Information Analysis

Different tools can be used to build successful foundations for the initial conversations with the prospect. For instance, mind maps provide a visual way of presenting information and allow the quick connecting of different dots/areas. It also helps to organise the data and create various relationships between other pieces, which as a result, simplifies the thinking process.

The following mind map provides an example of building the information about the "customer A" environment from a technical standpoint:

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<div style="width: 640px; height: 480px; margin: 10px; position: relative;"><iframe
allowfullscreen frameborder="0" style="width:640px; height:480px"
src="https://lucid.app/documents/embedded/c84e0d57-a0e2-4e77-8a51-3e1554ff09b3"
id="QxMxc3zldnvA"></iframe></div>
```

The complete example, was created based on the GitLab's customer and can be found with the above link for reference (accessible only internally).

This template can be used by the account team to brainstorm. The brainstorming session between the SA and SAE helps with the alignments of the future stages of the sales process, specifically focusing on "discovery", "scoping" and "technical evaluation".

Example Discussion Areas

Key areas driven by SA during the initial customer engagement include for example:

- Technological landscape
- Strategic technology initiatives
- Migrations from one technology to another
- Key technical stakeholders
- Any technical challenges, which organization is facing
- Application modernisation
- Microservice architecture and development process
- Key technical engagements and collaborations
- Agile practice and process
- Aligned GitLab capabilities / solutions
- Industry related initiatives, such as regulations and compliance, security mindset and practice

After the initial engagement and activities, asynchronous / synchronous collaboration can benefit the SAE and SA to analyze the current data and connect business points with the technical aspects. The SAE should provide the key directions from the business point of view to the solution architecture team. The SA can indicate the main areas or capabilities and the high level idea for solutioning, which should subsequent conversations with the customer.

During Technical Discovery and Scoping

Armed with the information synthesized, the initial set of calls or reviews with the customer can be oriented based on the personas engaged. The typical personas booked can be:

- DevOps or platform engineers
- App Dev team engineers
- DevOps team manager to director:
- Dev and Operations manager to director

For teams managing the DevOps tools such as DevOps or platform teams, listen to the challenges with tools and process, and identify if there are concerns for adoption by the app dev teams;

For the app dev teams, understanding the challenges with tools and process and how they may present any issues for software delivery;

During the call, listen and probe for the key information about:

- pain points and challenges, or opportunities
- what is the current solution and who owns it
- assess if it is transactional to solve a specific problem or pain point with a limited scope and the users with a prescribed solution
- listen and qualify if the problem identified is in a silo by a single unit or it is an opportunity that is across the entire organization

Activities for Discovery and Scoping

SAE Driven Activities: setting the stage for the discovery with the meetings and right participants; during the call, take the notes, discover/confirm the organizational structure and approach

SA Driven Activities: during the call, more prescriptive in assessing the conversation as transactional vs strategic solution.

Activities driven by the SA + collaboration with the SAE

- Map out the technical team structure and work with the SAE to expand the stakeholders for discussion if we agree on the pre qualification
- Collaborate on the organizational priority + inject into the discussion for initiatives and changes that can drive the conversation beyond just tools / features

Transactional based solutioning

Not all calls will lead into the strategic solution selling and some of them will simply result in a transactional deal. For a more tactical and transaction based sell, here are some points to note:

- Point Solution: a customer is looking for a small team solution or a single stage to address a specific problem and required to integrate to existing tools
- Support: There is no sponsorship or initiative to investigate the bigger DevOps problem at a

broader scope

- Sentiment: Uncertain about the Platform approach where the individual or team is more focusing on a specific feature

Signs to Drive Strategic Discussion for a Broad Solution

The following aspects outline a more strategic dialog for SA to lead and engage with the customer:

- Appetite for process and structure re-alignment and change, such as
 - Agile process
 - Shift-left security
- Discussion on the organization mind set, people and culture instead of job tools / features:
 - DORA review of accelerated state of DevOps to become top performer for software delivery;
 - Drive developer's experience
- Team/Stakeholders: People we engaged in the discovery have adoption and change management for the organizational thinking instead of individual tools and technology change

When engaging with the topics that lead to good responses from the initial discussion, the SA can expand the topics and discussions to a higher level or to other influential stakeholders.

Value Stream Workshop may be positioned for deeper understanding and further solidify the strategic partnership and engagement.

Capabilities and Solutions

A SA can lead and identify required capabilities and solution framework upon the following information gathered and analysis performed:

- Information and knowledge on the current challenges, pains and problems
- Assessment of the opportunity as transactional based solutioning with limited features vs extending to strategic account planning (coordinate with SAE)
- May be a smaller land but earns the right for a bigger conversation

Capabilities for the DevOps platform should have been explored with the customers in these areas as example:

Developer Experience

- Code management with review and approval
- Ownership and process from develop, release and operate
- Team collaboration and transferable skills
- Talent retaining

Governance and Compliance

- Regulatory mandate
- Compliance and audits
- Change control

Security

- Application security
- Secure software development
- Security posture and Cybersecurity exposure

With these capabilities identified, the solution options can be considered:

DevSecOps with shift left security: security team is engaged and measurable business outcome is identified to improve the overall security posture while delivering the software faster;

Continuous Software Compliance with built-in compliance, governance, policies and audit needs: compliance and change management teams are engaged to ensure that the app teams have guidance and framework to deliver software with regulatory or enterprise standard compliance;

Automated Software Delivery by transforming and modernizing the continuous integration and delivery, and driving the organization to become the top performer in software delivery;

DevOps platform to leverage the DevOps innovations for a unified developer experience with scalable and reliable solution for large scale adoption.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/_index.md

The Subject Matter Experts (SME) Program is an initiative designed to help solutions architects (SAs) provide better support to customers. The program will identify and onboard subject matter experts in key areas, such as AI, security, and agile planning.

SMEs are Solutions Architects who will help SAs in their region to answer more-in-depths questions, provide deep technical expertise, and assist with customer demos and presentations when needed.

Goals

The goals of the SME Program are to:

- Provide fellow SAs with the knowledge and expertise they need to support customers effectively.
- Improve the quality of customer support by reducing the number of questions that SAs have to answer.
- Increase customer satisfaction by providing them with access to experts who can answer their questions quickly and accurately.

In order to fulfill the above goals, the SME Program will be structured appropriately, with defined Roles and Responsibilities..

Other areas of the SME Program include:

1. Complete SME Logistics - Collaboration Project, Google Groups, Slack Channels

2. SME Nomination and Onboarding \- The Process to Become a SME
3. Request a SME process - How to Request a SME on an opportunity to provide technical guidance and expertise
4. Requesting Collateral, Articles and Best Practices to be Created & Gathered
5. Holding Regular SME Cadences](/handbook/solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-cadences/)
6. Process to Gather Feedback from Customers, back to Product Management
7. How to Engage with, and Escalate to Product Management

Areas of Expertise

The SME Program, with formal PM engagement will initially focus on the following areas:

- AI
- Application Security
- Agile planning
- Dedicated

The following SME areas are also available but will not, as yet, require formal PM engagement:

- CI/CD & Runners
- Metrics and Observability
- Embedded DevOps Systems

Other areas may be added in the future, depending on customer and SA demand, such as:

- Other Verticals such as Telecommunications etc.
- MLOps

Responsibilities

In summary, the responsibilities of a SME includes

- Provide technical guidance and expertise
- Maintain collateral for each SME Area, Currently the CSM SMEs have collated resources and materials for each SME Area. They are maintained in Highspot at CS SME Hub of content.
- Gather feedback from customers
- Engage with product management.

In detail, SMEs will be responsible for the following:

- Provide Technical Guidance and Expertise for the field and/ or customer, often in the form of:
 - Staying up-to-date on the latest trends in their area of expertise.
 - Providing updates to SAs and CSMs on Regional Calls during "SME Corner"
 - Answering questions from SAs in the sme slack channels, as well as in StackOverFlow for Teams, the official Knowledge Base.
 - Responding to Requests from SAs to assist on opportunities.
 - Office hours to enable other SAs or CSMs
 - Collaborate with Demo Architects on workshop updates and assist Solutions Architects with

new feature adoption.

- Participate in field enablement activities such as Technical Skills Exchange.
- Customer Success Plans reviews
- Deliberate practice
- Form communities of practices among the SMEs for the same topic and with fellow SAs to foster the knowledge in the team.
- Maintain Collateral in the Handbook or Highspot such as the CS SME Hub of content, to be used independently by account teams, including:
 - Maintain List of SMEs (also in StackOverflow) and SME Associates
 - Develop and deliver training materials on their area of expertise.
 - Creating a list of discovery questions to be used during discovery process by SAs
 - Creating frequently asked questions by customers per category
 - Gather and categorize recorded enablement sessions
 - Work with PMs to maintain FAQs for each Area
 - Create Golden demos
 - Hands-on workshops
 - Technical evaluation guidelines
 - POV templates
 - Common notional architecture diagrams
 - Competitive intelligence
- Work with Enablement to ensure SA SME onboarding is updated. Put together a sequence of tasks, by which an SA can gain expertise in a particular area.
- Engage Product Management and Gather Customer Feedback from the field to share with product and account teams, such as:
 - Be a counterpart to the Product Manager in the corresponding product group
 - Communicate with PMs and update the field via a shared medium of communication
 - Ensure that SAs are submitting customer feedback for PM review
 - Review and analyze submissions for patterns, get more context from SAs
 - Meet with their SME Area Leads, at least once a month, async, to calibrate submissions, assign priorities, and prepare to present to PMs a narrative
 - Maintain Issue Board of customer feedback and PM statuses
 - Meet with PMs once a month to review high priority submissions
 - get updates from PMs or work being done
 - ensure submissions are being updated
 - Contribute to product documentation

For other roles including SME Associates, SME Area Lead/ DRI and SME Program Lead, go to SME Responsibilities for further details.

Time Commitment

SMEs are expected to dedicate approximately 10-15% of their time to SME-related activities. This includes:

- Answering questions from other SAs
- Participating in SME/Product meetings
- Developing and delivering training materials
- Staying up-to-date with their area of expertise

The remaining 85-90% of their time will be dedicated to their regular SA responsibilities.

Recognition and Growth

Being an SME provides opportunities for professional growth and recognition:

- Increased visibility within the organization
- Opportunities to present at internal and external events
- Potential for career advancement
- Recognition in performance reviews

SMEs will be regularly evaluated based on their contributions and impact on the SA team and customer satisfaction. Here is the list of SME Metrics that would be gathered to quantify the impact of a SME's contribution.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-cadences.md

SME Cadence Framework

1. The SME Program and SME Area Leads should set up the calendar of SME calls and cadences as specified by the framework below.
2. Each program should have two calls per month, one, to calibrate, manage, allocate, categorize and prioritize requests, and the second to meet with the PMs for any updates.
3. The SME Program Lead should ensure that SME Area Leads are represented in the ARR Driver meeting and PMs would be in attendance.
4. The SME Area Leads should set up appropriate SME slack channels

Month	1				2				3							
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Week	1		2		3		4		1		2		3		4	
ARR Driver (once a Quarter)						X										
SME Area Pods (at least once a month)	AI		App Security		Agile		Dedicated		AI		App Security		Agile		Dedicated	
PM/ SME Cadence per Area (once a month (two weeks after SME Calibration meetings))	Agile		Dedicated		AI		App Security		Agile		Dedicated		AI		App Security	
SME Leaders Meeting (once a quarter)							X									
Regional SME Corner Updates (Weekly in Team calls)	X		X		X		X		X		X		X		X	
Technical Skills Exchange (Bi-weekly webinars) Attendees: SAs CSMs PMS SMEs																

ARR Driver Meeting

The objective of this meeting is to provide a forum in which SME Leads, along with Field CTOs, selected SA Leaders, and with cross functional leaders, meet to discuss main themes, roadmap items that can drive ARR at GitLab

Audience:

Selected Solution Architect Leaders and Field CTOs
All SME Area Leads
PMs from different Stages

Schedule and Timeline

Frequency: Once a Quarter

Product Management/ SME Area Cadence Meeting {sme-product-cadence}

SME Area Leads would chair the meeting along with their PM counterparts, review the SME Area Issue board, and give context on any prioritized new requests.

SMEs (and Opportunity SAs if needed) will attend to add more color where needed. PMs can relay updates on existing requests back to the SMEs. Everyone gets updated at the same time.

Since GitLab releases are once a month, this also can be an opportunity for PMs to demo, enable, or solicit feedback from SMEs on upcoming changes, or even solicit beta participants for future functionality.

Audience:

All SMEs for that Area
Opportunity SAs as needed
Engineering Manager (recommended)
SME Area Lead (Co-Host)
PM (Co-Host)

Schedule and Timeline

Frequency: Once a Month (two weeks after SME Area Calibration meetings)

Agenda

SMEs to Review New and Updated Customer Requests

SME Area Lead would review new customer requests with PMs. Set Status as reviewed

PMs to highlight which requests would be backlogged, or accepted as per SLA

PMs to relay any updates to any requests, that can be relayed backed to customers

Facilitate joint customer visits or calls between SMEs and Product Managers to gather direct feedback and understand customer needs.

Customer Trends and Adoption

Implement a system for SMEs to track and report on new feature adoption and impact in their regions, providing valuable data to Product Management.

Feedback loop where SMEs can share customer insights and market trends with Product Management to inform product decisions.

Collateral Updates

Involve SMEs in updating or creating FAQs for the handbook to ensure accurate and up-to-date information.

Review the topics for the next Technical Skills exchange.

SME Enablement Updates

Organize opportunities for SMEs to shadow Product Managers to better understand the product development process and decision-making.

PMs can engage request SMEs to participate in beta programs to test and provide feedback on new features before general release.

PMs to demo, enable, or solicit feedback from SMEs on upcoming changes, or even solicit beta participants for future functionality.

PMs to update roadmap presentations, walk through any new functionality, and share with SMEs so that they can deliver roadmap presentations as appropriate.

Technical Skills Exchange {sme-tech-skills}

The Technical Skills Exchange initiative should be supported by all SMEs.

On a bi-weekly basis, PMs and SMEs can meet to enable the SA and CSM community, to facilitate demos, and update the SA, and CS org on topics that can reduce the gap of knowledge the field has.

SMEs should use the Technical Skills Exchange to suggest and present on topics, as appropriate. This is the forum by which SMEs can learn and share their knowledge in the form of demos, mini workshops, and other formats.

The SME Area is responsible to ensure that recordings are categorized by Area: AI, App Security, Agile, Dedicated, CICD, Observation and placed in HighSpot or in the Handbook to form a list of resources by which we can onboard and train new SMEs. This should be used by all SME Associates to gain expertise in different areas.

Each Technical Skills Exchange, no matter the topic or format, should cover:

Context (Why does this feature exist)

What was the thinking behind the new functionality, why was it needed

What is the experience without this functionality? What would a customer resort to, or risk not having this functionality

Any Architectural principles for implementation.

Solution \<-- What is the GitLab solution/ demo it

Value (What happens when you have 100's of this thing)

What is the value to customers

What are the principles to adopt this at scale.

SME Leaders Meeting

SME Program Lead should meet with all SME Area Leads at least once a quarter

Audience:

All SME Area Leads

SME Program Lead (Host)

Schedule and Timeline

Frequency: (At Least) Once a Quarter

Agenda

Review SME program cadences

Review calendar of SME calls for all areas

Review appointment and rotation of SME Area Leads

Any adjustments needed in Customer Feedback Framework, templates, prioritization process

Review metrics in SME Utilization and Impact

Review any adjustments needed in PM Engagement

Help onboard any new SME programs or SME Areas

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-collateral.md

SME Content and Collateral (TBD)

NOTE: Currently the CSM SMEs have collated resources and materials for each SME Area. They are maintained in Highspot at CS SME Hub of content.

This is description of the CS SME program taking the lead on the gathering of collateral for each SME Area

To effectively organize and scale SME knowledge, we can implement the following structure:

1. Discovery Questions

- Develop a comprehensive list of discovery questions for each SME area
- Categorize questions by topic, complexity, and customer segment
- Regularly update and refine questions based on customer interactions

2. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

- Compile FAQs for each SME domain
- Provide clear, concise answers with relevant examples
- Include links to additional resources or documentation

3. Standard Demos

- Create a library of standardized demos for common use cases
- Ensure demos are easily customizable for specific customer needs
- Maintain version control and update demos regularly

4. Knowledge Base

- Develop a centralized repository for SME knowledge
- Organize content by topic, product area, and difficulty level
- Include best practices, troubleshooting guides, and case studies

5. Learning Paths

- Design structured learning paths for each SME area
- Include recommended resources, training materials, and hands-on exercises
- Define milestones and assessments to track progress

6. Collaboration Tools

- Implement tools for SMEs to share knowledge and collaborate
- Set up regular knowledge-sharing sessions and workshops
- Encourage cross-functional collaboration between SMEs and other teams

7. Mentorship Program

- Establish a mentorship program pairing experienced SMEs with aspiring experts
- Define clear goals and expectations for mentors and mentees
- Track progress and provide feedback on mentorship relationships

8. Continuous Improvement

- Implement a feedback loop to gather insights from SAs and customers
- Regularly review and update SME content based on feedback and industry trends
- Measure the effectiveness of SME resources and adjust strategies accordingly

By implementing this structure, we can effectively scale SME knowledge, provide clear paths for skill development, and ensure consistent, high-quality support for customers across all SME areas.

The CS org has already started on content gathering, and creation of content. They have been meeting in Pods to accomplish this.

Here is the HighSpot page for the CS SME Hub of content. Here is the CS SME Charter that talks about solving the problem of version controlled enablement content.

How can SAs help: We need to also have a process to scale the SME knowledge beyond the SMEs, for example: creating discovery questions, creating frequently asked questions by customers per and creating or using some standard demos..

How can Enablement Help: We can approach enablement to structure the content so that if someone wants to become a SME there is a path. This is a long term outcome.

The Technical Skills Exchange initiative can be utilized to that effect

StackOverflow (TBD)

Make sure that whoever is designated as an SME is listed as such in Stack Overflow. This will ensure that questions tagged with those relevant topics get routed to the right folks.

It should be part of the regular rigor that SMEs review questions in Slack (specifically cs-questions) and Stack Overflow to ensure the answers are upvoted and relevant as new changes/features get released.

We can also use Stack Overflow for FAQs and Articles related to those particular areas.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-customer-feedback.md

Customer Feedback Loop

Review Customer Issues Prioritization Framework

PMs Create issues under gitlab.org/issues especially for customer prioritization; prefer to have customer feedback template included as comments

Gathering and systematically relaying top asks from the field and customers to Product Management and Engineering, is one of the main responsibilities of a SME.

This allows a collective view of feedback from the field with analysis, so that it does not always seem reactive, but constructively adds to and builds on a roadmap, with roadmap themes.

The subject matter expert program can share the top ten requests from the field, with predetermined themes/ categories, rather than react individually or just have them go to a issue wasteland.

1. SAs and CSMS submit customer feedbacks and asks from the field via a process to be determined.
1. SMEs for each Area should analyze and prioritize the asks via a point system async or on one of their pod cadence calls.
1. The top requests are presented and discussed by the SME Area Leads at the monthly SME/ PM Cadence meetings
1. The status of the requests are updated. Updates are relayed back to the SMEs for each Area who then provides updates during a regional SME call or SME Corner updates.

Customer Feedback Framework and Process (TBD)

Customer Feedback Submission

TODO: Review Customer Issues Prioritization Framework

1. Implement a GitLab issue template with the following fields, for customer feedback submission from SMEs:
 - Customer name
 - Opportunity details
 - Net ARR or ARR basis
 - Use case description:
 - Current challenge/context
 - Proposed solution
 - Expected impact
 - Program theme/sub-category
 - List of other interested customers
2. Set up appropriate SME labels for the issue created, along with labels needed by Product Management
3. Assign Issues to appropriate themes (TBD)

Feedback Categorization

1. Collaborate with Product Managers to define sub-categories for each Program Area.
2. Example sub-categories for AI:
 - Chat

- Code suggestion
- Vulnerability analysis

Prioritization System

1. Develop an automated point system based on request attributes:
 - Customer tier
 - Potential revenue impact
 - Number of interested customers
 - Alignment with strategic goals
2. Implement a GitLab CI/CD job to calculate and assign points to each request.

SME Review Process

1. Schedule SMEs pod meetings in each Program Area to:
 - Review and validate point assignments
 - Adjust priorities as needed
 - Provide context to SME Area DRIs

Feedback Tracking

1. Create a "Top Requests" list for each Program Area.
2. Set up an issue board for each SME Area in GitLab, using the appropriate SME Labels with the following statuses:
 - New
 - Accepted by PM
 - Added to Roadmap
 - Resolved
 - Declined
 - Backlog

PM Collaboration

1. Schedule monthly meetings between SME Area Leads and Product Managers.
2. Use these meetings to review the SME Area Issue Board and discuss request statuses.

Communication and Updates

1. Include time in regional SA meetings for SMEs to present their Program Area's Issue Board.
2. Allow for verbal requests during these presentations.
3. Establish a process for SMEs to provide updates during SME Corner sessions.

Request Classification

1. Implement a system to differentiate between:
 - Feature requests
 - Bugs
 - Enhancements
2. Ensure appropriate routing and handling based on classification.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-engage-pm.md

The Challenge

Product Managers at GitLab have been expected to be available to answer every question, technical or otherwise, in any slack channel they are tagged, along with meeting customers at a moment's notice. This puts a strain on the capacity of GitLab's Product Managers (PMs).

One of the outcomes of the Subject Matters Expertise program is to allow the PMs to scale, by being the first line of experts to answer technical questions, and offer assistance on opportunities as requested by SAs and AEs.

This frees up the Product Management who can then be utilized as points of escalation, meet customers when appropriate and focus on roadmap development and delivery.

So in lieu of getting 150 requests from 150 different SAs or CSMS, if the SME program can reduce that by 50%, PMs can focus on empowering the SMEs and answering SMEs when they are stuck.

The field team should be able to self-service most of the sales activities for selling our products. SMEs are a way to support the wider Sales account teams.

How can SMEs and PMs assist each other

SMEs assist PMs, and support the wider Sales teams by:

1. Participating in product discovery sessions and strategy workshops leveraging their domain expertise.
1. Delivering deep technical overviews and assisting on opportunities
1. Answering technical questions asked by other SAs and AEs, in the sme- channels, especially on behalf of customers.
1. Maintaining a Knowledge Base, with often asked questions with answers.
1. Contributing to documentation, go to market materials, and other sales enablement.
1. Engaging with customers to gather feedback, better understand what are the gaps in achieving outcomes
1. Collaborate in / Create issues to improve the product.
1. Spotting opportunities to expand our product offering or reduce gaps
1. Raising the feedback from the field with the PMs and EMs on a regular cadence
1. Enabling the rest of the team on the SME area - sharing new insights, updates, learnings, etc. on team calls

As part of this symbiotic relationship, we expect GitLab Product Management, as part of a soft contract, to assist the SME program by:

1. Meeting with SMEs at least once a month to enable SMEs and provide an understanding on product changes, or give updates to product since last meeting
1. Being very responsive and available to answer questions from SMEs, or get clarifications from SMEs, in the appropriate sme-internal channels, so that SMEs can accurately assist other

resources. SLA: We expect PMs to respond to SME's inquiry within 4 hours in the SME internal channels.

1. Allow and give preference to SMEs, to shadow PMs, in the Shadow a PM program (TBD)
 1. Enable the field and provide roadmap updates during Technical Skills Exchange sessions.
 1. Provide roadmaps to customers.
 1. Give priority to issues raised by SMEs as part of the Gathering Customer Feedback process.
- We expect PMs to meet established SLAs as determined by that process.

How to Engage with Product Management

Resist from Directly contacting PM Without First completing an SME Request.

If an AE, a SA, or CSM requests a PM, Field CTO directly, ask the requester, to first consider requesting a SME. You, the SA/CSM can then request an SME in the appropriate SME channel.

PMs have been directed to redirect all questions to SMEs by the use of the SME Slack handles, if they determine that the SMEs were not initially engaged, and the request is not associated with any escalations, or request for product direction.

For other recommendations, please see Before Engaging or Requesting A PM Consider Requesting a SME First

When to Engage a Product Manager {sme-pm}

In summary, you can engage PMs, as noted in the Product Management, and How to Engage Product Managers sections of this Handbook, for the following scenarios:

1. Request for a Roadmap.
1. Discussion on the Direction of the Product.
1. Feedback and Questions on Gaps in Functionality
1. Request to join a Customer Meeting to discuss for gaps in functionality, roadmaps, or future direction of the product.
 1. Please follow the Product Management process to request a Customer Call
 1. NOTE: At no time should an AE, SA, or CSA request that a PM joins a call for tomorrow or the next day, especially just to answer technical questions, or best practices. See list of scenarios above where SMEs should be requested instead of a PM.
 1. Do not just simply request a Product Manager to join a call just because the AE insists, or you have not gathered the context or done any extensive discovery beforehand on exactly what the customer needs.
 1. During a POV, and you have already triaged with a SME as discussed above. This is usually the case assistance is needed on brand new functionality, or there is a need for a bug fix or enhancement.
 1. During a customer escalation, once the appropriate escalation process has been followed.

How to Engage/ Escalate to a PM, After engaging a SME

PMs should be engaged in customer opportunities, with at least 48hr notice for the following scenarios:

1. Request for a PM to meet with the Customer (one time, during evaluation, cadence calls).

2. Request for a PM to Resolve issues around product gaps
3. Request for a PM for Async involvement in Evaluations (trials, proof of value)

1. Request for a PM to meet with the Customer

- Do not expect PMs to attend calls to do discovery.
- To request a PM to attend a Customer Call, you should follow the process described in "Product Joining Customer Calls".
- PMs usually request a gathering of all customer context, filling out the PM Customer Meeting Briefing Document, and contacting the PMs in the slack channel for their group or category.

However some Stages may have a slight variation of this process, example Gitaly may require opening an issue.

See also following the standardized request process based on issues

2. Request for a PM to Resolve issues around Product Gaps

- Please refer to the SME Customer Feedback Process (TBD)

3. Request for a PM for Async involvement in Evaluations (trials, proof of value)

- SAs/ SMEs/ CSMs create Trial/ POV issues in Customer Collaboration Projects
- TBD (process to be Defined)

Other Opportunities to Engage with Product Management

Technical Skills Exchange

1. During Technical Skills Exchange Technical Product Managers and Product Managers to provide demos or demo snippets to SMEs for new functionality feedback.

Product Management Roadmap Meetings

1. Monthly meetings between SMEs and Product Managers to discuss upcoming releases, major new functionalities, and gather feedback.
1. Organize quarterly presentations by Product Managers or Technical Product Managers to SMEs, covering:
 - Changes in architecture
 - New use cases
 - Features and functionalities
 - Product roadmap updates
1. Establish a regular cadence for SMEs to review and provide input on product roadmaps, ensuring alignment with customer needs and market trends.

SME Slack Internal Channels

Product Management should also be included in SME Slack Internal channels to create a forum for

SMEs to provide ongoing feedback and suggestions to Product Management.

SME/Product Management Cadence Meetings

SMEs and PMs are expected to meet at least once a month. Some PMs also conduct their own office hours. See SME/ Product Management Cadence Meetings for suggested cadence and agenda.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-operations.md

StackOverflow (TBD)

The preferred channel is our StackOverFlow for Teams within cs-questions.

Maintain List of SMEs (also in StackOverFlow) and SME Associates

Make sure that whoever is designated as an SME is listed as such in Stack Overflow. This will ensure that questions tagged with those relevant topics get routed to the right folks.

It should be part of the regular rigor that SMEs review questions in Slack (specifically cs-questions) and Stack Overflow to ensure the answers are upvoted and relevant as new changes/features get released.

We can also use Stack Overflow for FAQs and Articles related to those particular areas.

TODO: Need to detail what exactly is the process to add SMEs to StackOverFlow

SME Google Groups

Each SA Area Lead should set up SA and CS SME Google Groups for calendars. Have also both SA program Leads owners also, as a backup in case SA Area Lead is OOO

Use list of SMEs to form Groups

SME Area	SME Group	
-----	-----	
SME Area Leads Group	sme-leaders	
AI	sme-ai	
Security & Compliance	sme-appsec	
Dedicated	sme-dedicated	
Plan	sme-plan	
CICD/Runner	sme-ci	
Metrics & Observability	sme-metrics	

Vertical SME Google Groups

Vertical	SME Group	
-----	-----	
Embedded DevOps	sme-embedded-devops	

Financial Services	sme-finserv	
Healthcare	sme-healthcare	
Telecommunications	sme-telco	

SME Slack Channels {sme-slack}

To facilitate effective communication and collaboration between Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) and the field teams, the following Slack channel structure is recommended:

SME Program Leadership Channel

Purpose: Async Coordination among SME Area Leaders on any changes or decisions made concerning the SME program.

SME Area	Slack Channels
SME Program Leadership Channel	sme-program-leaders

Channel for all SMEs in All Areas

Purpose: This is the main channel for all SME-related discussions and announcements. It serves as a central hub for:

- General SME program updates
- Cross-domain collaboration
- Sharing best practices and success stories
- Coordinating SME activities across different areas of expertise

SME Area	Slack Channel
All SMEs	subject-matter-experts

SME Area Internal Slack Channels {sme-internal}

Purpose: These SME Pod channels are mainly for SME Program Leads, SME Area Leads, SMEs and SME Associates. They are used for:

- Asynchronous meetings
- Discussions on architectural challenges
- Competitive analysis
- Identifying and addressing enablement needs
- Tracking and managing SME requests

SME Area	Slack Channel
AI	sme-ai-internal
Security & Compliance	sme-appsec-internal
Dedicated	sme-dedicated-internal
Plan	sme-plan-internal
CICD/Runner	sme-ci-internal

| Metrics & Observability | sme-metrics-internal |

SME Public Channels {sme-channels}

These channels are open to all SMEs, Product Managers (PMs), and all field members. They serve to:

- A place for team members supporting customer evaluations of GitLab features
- Submitting SME requests for specific opportunities
- Coordinating SME involvement in customer engagements
- Asking product questions pertaining to specific subject matters

SME Area	Slack Channel	
----- -----		
AI	sme-ai	
App Security & Compliance	sme-appsec	
Dedicated	sme-dedicated	
Plan	sme-plan	
CICD/Runner	sme-ci	
Metrics & Observability	sme-metrics	

Vertical SME Public Slack Channels

Vertical	Slack Channel	
----- -----		
Embedded DevOps	sme-embedded-devops	
Financial Services	vfinserveglobal	
Telecommunications	sme-telecommunications	
Healthcare	sme-healthcare	

SME Collaboration Projects

Each SME Area Lead should set up SME Collaboration project (See AppSec Example)

SME Area	Collaboration Project	
----- -----		
SME Program Logistics	SME Program Project	
AI	AI SME Project	
AppSec	App Security SME Project	
Dedicated	Dedicated SME Project	
Plan	Plan SME Project	
CICD/Runner	CI/CD SME Project	
Metrics & Observability	Metrics SME Project	
Aerospace Vertical	Aerospace SME Project	
Automotive Vertical	Automotive SME Project	
Embedded DevOps Vertical	Embedded DevOps SME Project	
Healthcare Vertical	Healthcare SME Project	
Financial Services Vertical	Financial Services SME Project	
Telecommunications Vertical	Telecommunications SME Project	

SME Metrics {sme-metrics}

To effectively measure the impact and success of the SME program, we will track the following metrics:

1. Technical Win Rate:

Metric: Percentage of wins in opportunities with SME involvement using SA Activity type SA Assistance - Subject Matter

Calculation: $(\text{Number of won opportunities with SME engagement} / \text{Total number of opportunities with SME engagement}) \times 100$

Goal: Increase win rate by 10% compared to baseline within 12 months

2. Knowledge Transfer Effectiveness:

Metric: Number of SME-led training sessions, knowledge base articles created and shared, and training session survey results

Calculation: Sum of training sessions conducted, articles published by SMEs, and session survey results average rating

Goal: Minimum of 4 training sessions and 10 knowledge base articles per quarter

3. Stack Overflow Engagement:

Metric: Response rate and quality of SME answers on Stack Overflow

Calculation: $(\text{Number of SME responses} / \text{Total number of relevant questions}) \times 100$; Average upvotes per SME answer

Goal: 90% response rate to relevant questions; Average of 5 upvotes per SME answer

Reporting and Analysis:

Generate quarterly reports to track progress and identify trends using visualization tools
Based on reports and survey data, conduct quarterly reviews to assess SME program effectiveness and make necessary adjustments

By consistently tracking and analyzing these metrics, we can ensure the SME program's continuous improvement and show its value to the organization.

New SME Area of Expertise Process

TBD - Define the process to determine whether a SME Area of Expertise should be established or not.

These are the differences between SMEs Areas of Interest and Formal SME Programs

	SME Area of Interest	Formal SME Areas
1. CI/CD/ Runners		1. CI/CD/ Runners
2. Metrics & Observability		2. Metrics & Observability
3. Embedded Systems		3. Embedded Systems
4. App Security		4. App Security
5. Dedicated		5. Dedicated
6. Plan Leadership Structure	No official SME Area Leader, or SMEs.	Can be a pool of interested folks of SME Associates.
7. One person driving program		[x] SME Area Leads
8. SMEs		[x] SMEs
9. SME Associates		[x] SME Associates
10. Formal List of SA and CS SMEs		[x] List of SME Associates or Interested Folks
11. SME Google Groups		[x] Slack Channels - General
12. Slack Channel - Request a SME		[] Slack Channel - Request a SME
13. Collaboration Project		[] StackOverFlow
14. Formal List of SA and CS SMEs		[x] Formal List of SA and CS SMEs
15. List of SME Associates		[x] SME Google Groups
16. Slack Channels		[x] Slack Channels

General
[x] Slack Channel - Request a SME
[x] Collaboration Project
[x] StackOverFlow
|
Cadences	[] ARR Driver [] SME Area Leads Meetings [x] SME Area Pod Cadences [] PM/ SME Area Cadences [x] PM Roadmaps [x] Technical Skills Exchange Meetings can be in the form of trainings, async, office hours etc 	[x] ARR Driver [x] SME Area Leads Meetings [x] SME Area Pod Cadences [x] PM/ SME Area Cadences [x] PM Roadmaps [x] Technical Skills Exchange
Process to Request a SME	No	Yes
Customer Feedback Mechanisms	No	Yes (with Issue Boards etc)
Engagement with PM	Some	Yes

Once a SMEs Area of Interest becomes a formal SME Programs These are the tasks needed to complete setup:

Selection of SME Area Leads, SMEs
Who decides on new SME Area
Rollout to SA and CS Community
Enrolling PMs
Maintain List of SA SME Participants - Confirm List of SMEs
Maintain list of potential SMEs (SME Associates) as a pool for each area
Create the necessary SME google groups for calendar purposes
1. Open an Access Request with IT to have the Google Group created.
2. Use the same naming convention as other SME areas, provide the DRI's as Group Owner and Group Manager. You can clone this issue as an example.
3. Once the Google Group has been created by IT the group owner/manager can navigate to the Google Groups page to add SME's as group members.
Set up Stack OverFlow with SMEs to answer questions.
Set up SME Collaboration project
1. Navigate to the SME Subgroup
2. Click New Project
3. Create your project using the same naming nomenclature as the other projects in the subgroup
Set up both a public SME Slack Channel for the field and a private internal channel for the SME pod using the naming conventions outlined above (example sme-(area) and sme-(area)-internal)
Update Handbook on SME Operations

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-program.md

SME Program Structure

The SME program will be chaired and led by an overall SME Program Lead, responsible for establishing and ensuring that all the SME processes are being adhered to by each SME Area.

The SME Program will consist of one or more SME Areas of expertise.
Each SME Area will be represented by two SME Area Lead/ DRI, one representative from the SA org, and one from the CS org. They will be responsible for the proper functioning of each area.

Each SME Area should be supported by at least one Product Manager and/or Engineering Manager representative.

In total, each SME AREA will consist of

1. Two SME Area Leads or DRIs - a SA representative and a CS representative
2. At least a Product Manager and/or Engineering Manager representative
3. At Least 3 SMEs, each selected from each of the following regions: EMEA NEUR, EMEA SEUR, DACH/ META, APAC, US East, US West, Commercial, Partners/Pub Sec.

For the SA Org, we recommend that there should be only one Subject Matter Expert (SME) representative per region, for each SME Area of expertise. This is to ensure that there is one SME per Area who is willing and responsible to carry out the responsibilities and tasks for the proper functioning of the SME program.

Each SME Area, therefore with both SA and CS Area Leads and all SA and CS SMEs can be referred to as a SME Area Pod. Each Pod will have their own cadence meetings. Both SA and CSMs can attend the same pod meeting.

SA SME Program Lead	CS SME Program lead

SME Area Pod	
SA SME Area Lead	CS SME Area Lead
SA Regional SME 1	CS SME 1
SA Regional SME 2	CS SME 2
SA Regional SME 3	CS SME 3

While it is highly recommended to have only one SA SME for each area per region, there can exist other subject matter experts (SME) or SME Associates. However one SA should be designated regional SME per area who will take on the responsibilities of being a SME DRI in the SME program, including maintaining collateral, gathering feedback from customers, engaging with product management.

Here is the list of the SMEs for each Area.

SME Roles

SME Associates

SMEs are expected in general to fulfill two main responsibilities:

Be experts and maintain a high level of expertise in their area, craft and domain
Be the DRI and be responsible for leading and directing various aspects associated with the SME program including, maintaining collateral, gathering feedback from customers, engaging with product management.

However there would be number of SAs (and CSMs) who, as part of their career development, would not desire or are not ready to participate as a DRI in the SME program, but would express

interest to focus and go technically deeper in one of the SE Areas: AI, App Security, Agile Planning, Dedicated, CI & Runners, Metrics and Observability.

Think of SME Associates as those potential SMES. who declare a major as they look to advance and graduate in their craft.

These are not the regional SME representatives, who are responsible for leading and directing various aspects of the SME program.

These are SME Associates. There are no limits to number of SAs who can express interest in becoming an expert in any one of the SME Areas. SME Area Leads will use their Collab project to track a list of Associates.

As an example, an SA manager can encourage all SA team members, in a geography or region, to express interest in having one or more focuses, as a part of their development, to improve their craft in that area.

SME Associates can be mentored by their regional SMEs.

SME Associates can form a pool from which the next Regional SME for a particular area can be selected.

SME Associates will proactively track their progress with list of contributions and mapping to skills required in preparation for becoming a SME. Skills required will vary based on the SME Area.

Full Responsibilities for this and other SME roles are detailed here.

SMEs (Regional SA representative for each SME Area)

SMEs are SAs and CSMs who, not only have declared a major, attained recognizable expertise, but who are selected officially to represent a region for a particular SME Area.

SMEs will be responsible for their area of expertise for their region, and to ensure the smooth running of the SME program.

SME's during their tenure in the program must be willing to have the specified time commitment

Full Responsibilities for this and other SME roles are detailed here.

SME Area Lead/ DRI

SME Area Leads/DRIs will be responsible for their area of expertise and leading their SME teams. They are the project managers for their SME Areas.

They are responsible for

Setting up and maintaining the calendar of SME calls for each areas
having regular cadences with the SME Area pod
maintain cadences and engage with Product Management.

maintaining the roster of SMEs and keeping track of SME Associates. Ensure that this roster is maintained in this handbook and in Stack Overflow

Maintain the membership of all Google Groups and SME Slack channels for their area.

Full Responsibilities for this and other SME roles are detailed here.

SME Program Lead

The SME Program Lead is responsible for:

Ensuring the SME program cadences are taking place

Ensure that SME Area leads are represented in ARR Driver Meetings

Ensure the appointment and rotation of SME Area Leads

Any adjustments needed in Customer Feedback Framework, templates, prioritization process

Maintaining the Process to engage SMEs

Track metrics in SME Utilization and Impact

Maintain relationships with PMs

Assist with SME Area Lead rotation and selection process

Help onboard any new SME programs

SME Responsibilities {sme-responsibilities}

| Main Responsibility | SME Associate | SME | SME Area Lead | SME Program Lead |

| :---- | :---- | :---- | :---- | :---- |

| Technical Guidance and Expertise | -Opportunity consultations <p>-Demo or presentation reviews
-Customer calls
-Participate in Enablement sessions
-Deliberate practice |
- Staying up-to-date on the latest trends in their area of expertise.
- Providing updates to SAs and CSMs on Regional Calls during "SME Corner"
- Answering questions from SAs about their area of expertise. The preferred channel is our StackOverflow for Teams via cs-questions.
- Providing technical expertise to SAs during customer demos and presentations.
- Office hours to enable other SAs or CSMs
- Participate in field enablement activities such as Technical Skills Exchange.
- Customer Success Plans reviews
- Deliberate practice
- Form communities of practices among the SMEs for the same topic and with fellow SAs to foster the knowledge in the team. | | |

| Maintain Collateral | |
-Creating a list of discovery questions to be used during discovery process by SAs
-Creating frequently asked questions by customers per category
-Maintain a list of Recorded enablement sessions for each Area in Highspot
-Work with PMs on FAQs Golden demos
-Hands-on workshops
-Technical evaluation guidelines
-POV templates
-Common notional architecture diagrams
-Competitive intelligence |
- Maintain List of SMEs (also in StackOverflow) and SME Associates
- Develop and deliver training materials on their area of expertise
- Creating a list of discovery questions to be used during discovery process by SAs
- Creating frequently asked questions by customers per category
- Gather and categorize recorded enablement sessions
- Work with PMs to maintain FAQs for each Area
- Create Golden demos
- Hands-on workshops
- Technical evaluation guidelines
- POV templates
- Common notional architecture diagrams
- Competitive intelligence
- Work with Enablement to ensure SA SME onboarding is updated. Put together a sequence of tasks, by which an SA can gain expertise in a particular area. | |

| Customer Feedback/ PM Engagement | |
- Be a counterpart to the Product Manager in the corresponding product group
- Communicate with PMs and update the field via a shared medium of communication
- Ensure that SAs are submitting customer feedback for PM review
-

Review and analyze submissions for patterns, get more context from SAs
- Meet with their SME Area Leads, at least once a month, async, to calibrate submissions, assign priorities, and prepare to present to PMs a narrative
- Maintain Issue Board of customer feedback and PM statuses
- Meet with PMs once a month to review high priority submissions
- get updates from PMs or work being done
- ensure submissions are being updated
- Contribute to product documentation |
-Lead the Review and analysis submissions for patterns,
-get more context from SAs
-Ensure that submissions are properly tagged with the right themes
-Set up and Lead meeting with SME Area Leads globally, at least once a month, async, to calibrate submissions, assign priorities, and prepare to present to PMs a narrative
-Lead the maintenance of Issue Board of customer feedback and PM statuses
-Set up and Lead meetings with PMs once a month to review high priority submissions,
-get updates from PMs of work being done,
-ensure submissions are being updated.
-Maintain relationships and collaboration with PMs
-Select Customer Feedback that would drive revenue, and meet with other SME Area Leads once a quarter in ARR Driver meeting
-Arrange for PMs to enable SAs,
-gain access to Beta functionality etc.
-Contribute to product documentation | | | Manage SME Program | | |
-Ensuring the SME program cadences are taking place
-Maintain the calendar of SME calls for all areas
-Ensure that SME Area leads are represented in ARR Driver Meetings
-Ensure the appointment and rotation of SME Area Leads
-Any adjustments needed in Customer Feedback Framework, templates, prioritization process
-Maintaining the Process to engage SMEs
-Track metrics in SME Utilization and Impact
-Maintain relationships with PMs
-Assist with SME Area Lead rotation and selection process
-Help onboard any new SME programs |

SME Selection, Nomination and Rotations {sme-selection}

SME Associates

SAs and CSMs as part of their 1-1 process, mid year review, Individual Growth Plans, should indicate a desire to focus on a particular area of the GitLab Platform

SA manager should make this known to the SMEs for their regions

SMEs along with SA managers should ensure that SAs who express this interest should follow a program to gain the necessary expertise. This can take the form of mentorship, office hours, certifications, a prescribed set of training, videos, demos, support for workshops and field events.

SMEs (Regional)

1. SMEs should be prepared to be in the role for at least a year and up to 2 years.
2. SMEs SA Associates who are interesting in representing their regions should make that known to their SA managers
3. SA managers within a region or geographical area should collaborate together, to review areas of expertise and relevant experience. and choose a SME to represent their region
4. Make the SME Area Lead aware of any change in a SME for the region.

SME Area Leads and SA Program Lead

The nomination and selection process for SME Area Leads will be as follows:

1. SME Area Leads should be prepared to be in the role for at least a year and up to 2 years.
2. SME Program Lead should be prepared to be in the role for at least 18 months and up to 3 years.
3. Open call for applications: SAs and existing SMEs who are interested in becoming SME Area Leads can apply by submitting their areas of expertise and relevant experience. The Product Management team is also invited to recommend a nominee.
4. Review of applications: A panel consisting of senior SAs and leadership will review the applications.
5. Selection: The panel will select SME Area Leads based on their areas of expertise and relevant experience.
6. Onboarding: Selected SME Area Leads will undergo a brief onboarding process to familiarize with their new responsibilities and expectations.

SME Training

Training to become a SME can take the form of mentorship, office hours, certifications, a prescribed set of training, videos, demos, support for workshops and field events. Each SME Area will determine the necessary training path for new SMEs. For example, this Issue describes the skill levels and associated skills expected to be customer ready as a Dedicated SME.

In addition, SMEs should be given the opportunity to attend conferences and speak on behalf of GitLab in their area of expertise.

We will offer a Shadow a PM program in the future.

Currently the CSM SMEs have collated resources and materials for each SME Area. They are maintained in Highspot at CS SME Hub of content.

The Goal in the future is to organize the content in a prescribed way to allow a SME Associate to gain expertise to become a SME.

SME Onboarding

When a new SME for any area is selected, the following steps will be taken:

1. The SME receives approval from their direct manager to participate in the SME program for their region.
2. The new SME will complete any required on-boarding for the SME Area. Required on-boarding will be decided by each area. Examples, Embedded and Dedicated on-boarding Issue templates.
3. Add the SME to the relevant Google Group and Slack Group for their Area of Expertise. This will ensure that the SME is added automatically to all cadence calls for that Area.
4. Add the SME to the appropriate Stack Overflow team area to begin answering questions
5. Add the SME to the appropriate SME Slack Channel
6. As a new SME, strive to contribute to a new request for help, shared content review, Stack Overflow question, or other helpful effort.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/subject-matter-experts/sme-request.md

A system needs to be set up on how to request a SME for an opportunity. One of the responsibilities of a SME is to "Providing technical expertise to SAs during customer demos and presentations with a shared slack channel or joining customer calls."

To request a Subject Matter Expert (SME) for an opportunity, follow these steps:

Submit a request:

To submit a request for help from a SME, select the SME Request workflow in the Slack channel from the "Workflows" tab below the channel name.

Alternatively, you can type "/s